

[Return to Search](#)

Modes of persuasion

Author(S): Rasmussen, Susan J.

Document Type: Article

Original Page: 35

Culture (OWC): [Tuareg \(MS25\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Northern Africa

Field Date: 1974-1991

Coverage Date: 1970-1990

Place Coverage: Niger

Section Title(S): Conflict In A Polygynous Household

A central cultural value among Tuareg is *takarakit*, or reserve, to which both sexes are subject, but women in particular must observe it in selecting suitors, lovers, or fiances. Personal preference may be expressed only indirectly, through poetry and song. Hidden sentiments—love, anger, and resentment, plagued Tina and she felt caught in a double-bind between the ideal, as yet unfulfilled, of economic security in marriage to a prosperous polygynist gardener and personal unhappiness from his actual neglect. She frequently approached Hadia for money and clothing. Although sisters feel rivalry in contributing amounts to parents' storehouse, they often share food and lend moral support. Hadia considered local marabouts, who had helped arrange Tina's marriage, to be unsympathetic, so she walked some distance to take her sister's case to higher judicial levels: the chief of El Meki, a village about ten miles from her home. But for several months nothing was done. Hadia and Tina lamented this state of affairs to me, and threatened to eventually take the case to the Sultan of Agadez, if necessary. Unlike some other Tuareg women, Hadia was not at all reticent about her resentments. She enjoyed some degree of freedom from constraint, due to her single status, her economic independence, and servile origins, these latter conferring greater freedom from noble values of reserve and restraint. Yet some slave women attempt to imitate nobles in display of these constraints for reasons of prestige, particularly when they need to compensate for uncertain resources. Tina, as a married woman in principle entitled to equal resources, but in reality with limited access to them, felt more acutely these inhibitions. In fact, a common expression she repeated to me was “singlehood is like a wooden fence, marriage is like a mud wall.”

- 156
Social Personality
- 181
Ethos
- 562
Gender Status
- 578
Ingroup Antagonisms
- 582
Regulation Of Marriage
- 593
Family Relationships

Mutual friends told me women who experience conflicts but suppress them “suffer from failing to act on their (true) desires,” and a condition called *tamazai* results. This approximately translates as depression, specifically resulting from failing to openly express one's sentiments. *Tamazai* may bring on possession by spirits of a type incurable by Koranic verses. They require instead music, noise, and jokes of an exorcism rite, featuring a drummer (usually a lower-caste individual such as a smith or ex-slave), a chorus of young women, and mixed-sex audience of diverse social segments. Tina became subject to frequent attacks of spirits, and her mother and sister staged a rite for her on a number of occasions. Hadia played the drum, called a *tende*, constructed from a mortar normally used to crush grain. The songs are selected by the patient and are believed to have a soothing effect to dull pain and “transport the sufferer beyond herself.” Verses from one of the songs performed at a ritual for Tina I observed appear below:

Follow me in singing
 I am an orphan
 I am a child
 Burned in love
 That which has left my soul
 like milk and water together
 like the taste of salted meat in the mouth
 It arrives in the liver and attaches itself
 Like the cushion of a camel saddle
 Made of bands stitched closely together
 It glides like water on a smooth rock
 It reaches the liver like the well-attached branches of the
 tent
 It penetrates like water does the well
 Alas, my soul
 Oh, my singing partners
 Applaud and keep time to the song
 Clearly the creator who possesses me
 Refresh my liver
 which cannot be refreshed by water
 It must have milk kept from the milking of young cows
 from very young cows of the Icherifan clans, kept in
 gourds.

533
 Music

562
 Gender Status

578
 Ingroup Antagonisms

756
 Shamans And
 Psychotherapists

786
 Ecstatic Religious
 Practices

787
 Revelation And
 Divination

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: ✉ hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs: ✉ hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)